Session 6

2025-03-09

1 – Evening at the keep

~17:00, 24 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Back at the keep after the camp recon, the party debriefs again with **Tarbaw** in the common room. Sinsong asks whether the captured cultist Miguel brought back from the southern excursion has talked.
2. Tarbaw answers heavily — neither prisoner survived the interrogation. **Escobert** worked both of them; one yielded the camp's location before dying, the other gave nothing. Tarbaw says drily that Escobert is *exceptionally good at extracting information*.
3. Tarbaw remarks that with both prisoners dead the cult's most valuable witness is **Leosin Erlanthar**, and the party did not bring him back. Nyx answers flatly that they lost sight of him; Mialee adds that the monk did not come on his own. Tarbaw waves it off — they have done enough already.
4. Amidamaru asks whether the town has anyone left to rescue. Tarbaw confirms several prisoners were taken to the camp; the party admits they did spot the eight at the latrines but were detected and forced to flee.
5. The party settles in. Mialee asks after a pearl in town — Tarbaw shakes his head, the looters cleaned out anything of value. Nyx orders a drink; Sinsong joins her. The party spends the next two hours drinking in the keep's common room.
6. Sinsong asks Tarbaw before bed what the keep needs of them tomorrow. Tarbaw answers that recovery is the priority — the guards are still tending the wounded; help with that is welcome.
7. The party calls an early night and retreats to the barracks, sleeping soundly until the next morning.

2 – Morning briefing

~08:00, 25 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party comes down to the keep's hall and finds **Nesim Waladra** waiting for them with another figure. The second man wears traveller's robes and a monk's bearing; the party recognises him from the valley. It is **Leosin Erlanthar**.
2. Leosin greets them. He looks bruised and gaunt but visibly recovered; the cuts from the stake are scarred over. He thanks them for their help with a wry remark that they *could have helped a bit more*, but the healing on the rim was what mattered.
3. Asked how he escaped, Leosin says the distraction fire drew the cultists toward the eastern tents and the prisoner stakes; the middle of the bowl emptied long enough for him to slip into the tents, knock out two guards along the way, and climb out by the north face.
4. Amidamaru gives him medical advice to help the morning's recovery. Sinsong approaches, shakes his hand, and wishes him a swift recovery — the monk's colour comes up, reinvigorated.
5. Leosin admits why he is really here. He must travel north to Elturel to report to his order; he cannot stay. He asks the party to return to the camp and bring back what they can on the heavily-guarded cave at the east end — the cult are calling it a *hatchery*, and that word alone is what he most wants verified. He offers them a reward: **one hundred and fifty gold pieces per head**.
6. Asked what the cave might hold, Leosin spreads his hands — kobolds, dragons, something else; that is what he wants the party to find out. Asked whether he saw treasure carried out, he confirms steady movement of cultists and pack-drakes hauling crates into it. They are using it as a stockpile at the least.
7. Nyx asks Leosin about his order. He answers that he is just a monk — his order is secular rather than religious; he works in concert with the Council of Lords and the Order of the Gauntlet, gathering intelligence to head off further raids like Greenest. He is from Berdusk; Elturel is one stop on his northward route.
8. If the party arrives at Elturel and Leosin has already moved on, they should ask for **Ontharr Frume** of the Order of the Gauntlet.
9. Leosin recommends a proper rest before they go back to the valley. The party agrees and spends the morning resupplying — rations, arrows, rope. Sinsong complains about the weight of all the gear he is carrying; Eguzkilore leaves most of his pack in a chest at the keep.
10. They set out before noon, retracing their route south at an easy pace. First open ground, then the foothills. At the chokepoint where the defile ambush hit them two days earlier they slow to a crawl — and find it *empty*, no scouts, no signs of fresh movement.
11. After four hours walking, they finally approach the bowl. The lower gate that bristled with crossbowmen on the previous run is *unmanned*.

3 – The camp emptied out

~13:30, 25 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. From the rim they take in the change. The kobolds' shanty quarter at the camp's lower end is *burned to the ground* — the lean-tos torched along their entire run, only the central tower and the better-built shelters still standing. There is no smoke now; the burn is hours old.
2. A circuit of the perimeter shows what happened. Many small parties have broken from the camp through the main gate, each then turning off in a different direction once clear. The heavier-loaded tracks — including a few cart-trails — all bear **west**. The lighter parties scatter every which way.
3. Sinsong puts on the cultist robe again and the party walks in. Four armed humans at a small tent on the upper terrace see them coming; the men are sitting at their bows and traps, calm. One looks up, points casually at the cave, and tells Sinsong — without bothering to lower his voice — that *the friend in the bushes does not need to hide; they are not staying*. The four mount waiting horses and gallop off.
4. With the camp clear the party works the tents room by room. The hunters' shelter holds bedrolls for sixteen and nothing of value. The robed cultists' tents have been stripped down to broken pottery and household scraps. The well-decorated central tent — where **Rezmir** and the others had emerged the day before — is empty too.
5. The household debris is worthless to the party but useful to the people of Greenest. Nuberroca packs about seventy-five kilos of plates, cutlery, and pots into an improvised bundle to carry on the way out, complaining as he does so about losing his stealth. Nyx sweeps the central tent for anything of value and finds ten gold pieces scattered between bedding.
6. With the camp checked, they turn for the eastern cave.

4 – The cave mouth

~14:30, 25 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Sinsong listens at the entrance — running water, the natural acoustics of a deep cave, nothing else. Nuberroca crouches to read the prints at the threshold: drake tracks, days fresh, plus human boot-prints layered over them. Past the threshold the dark is broken by a *soft purple light* from further in.
2. The dwarf casts magical light on a small plate from the tent loot and gives it to Amidamaru for illumination. Amidamaru, who lived three decades underground, returns it with a polite thanks.
3. Mialee scouts first, stepping past a column at the bend. Two attackers waiting in cover behind the column move on her in one motion — coordinated, fast, each striking twice. Before the rest can react **Mialee is on the ground, bleeding out**.
4. Nyx hears her cries from the bend. Nuberroca, seeing Mia drop, *rages* — he had not meant to, but the small one going down decides it for him. He feels the surge run through him, increasing his vitality, and pushes a portion of it across to Eguzkilore.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca closes and brings his greataxe down on the first attacker — a clean swing, the man dead before he can lift his weapon again. Eguzkilore's bow drops the second.
6. Sinsong reaches Mia, stabilises her with his magic, then closes her worst wound with a healing — the elf opens her eyes, alive and on her feet again. Mialee, light-headed, finds a *vial of green liquid* on the body next to her and pockets it.
7. The cleric lays a magical bond on Amidamaru, Mialee, and Nuberroca — they feel their skills honed for the combat.

5 – The fungi chamber

1. Past the column the cave opens into a wider hall lit purple. Stone stairs lead down into it. Nuberroca takes the lead; partway down one of the treads sinks under him and the staircase *folds flat into a ramp* — he tumbles to the floor in a heap of plates and gear.
2. He picks himself up to find the chamber's floor carpeted with fungi. Several are knee-high; *four are taller than a person*, glowing softly purple, swaying without wind.
3. Nyx asks whether any of them are edible. Nuberroca, who has seen mountain fungi like them, answers that these are *dangerous* — to eat, and worse to touch.
4. The large fungi prove him right at once. They lurch toward him in the same swaying motion; on contact they secrete a putrid slick that eats at his skin. The first strike opens his arm; a faint blue glow runs across the wound and closes it partially. The second slick gets past the heal, the substance visibly melting through his hide where it touches.
5. Mialee shoots from cover. Eguzkilore puts another arrow in the damaged fungus. Nyx marks the wounded fungus and lands a third arrow.
6. Amidamaru, on the steps above, throws a bolt of fire down at the wounded fungus. The shot burns it badly but the thing holds together; the others keep coming.
7. The fungi keep grinding at Nuberroca, the rot biting deep. He drops the closest one with a greataxe sweep, then the next, then the third. The last falls to a combined volley from the steps.
8. Nuberroca turns to Sinsong with a gash along one arm still bleeding the brown slick of the rot. Sinsong sighs at him, calls down a healing, and the wound closes. Nuberroca claps the dwarf on the shoulder and tells him that in his tribe, when someone saves your life *you become blood brothers* — and Sinsong is now his blood brother. Sinsong submits to it with a flat look, mutters about needing to be more careful, and turns away — at which Nuberroca, grinning, adds, *"Gracias, me encanta cómo te luce la calva cuando me curas."*
9. From the chamber they spot a corridor behind them, with a side passage to the left and a broader chamber at the end. Eguzkilore sees barrels stacked at the back.
10. The party sweeps the broken-down storeroom on the right. Sinsong digs through abandoned chests and turns up sixteen gold pieces — nothing else of value, only smashed pottery and ash.
11. On the floor of the same room they find a cultist — sprawled, *blackout drunk*. Nuberroca disarms him, ties him with rope, then slaps him hard enough to draw a groan and nothing more. The bundle of plates and the unconscious cultist together would weigh over a hundred and eighty kilos, so the barbarian leaves the cultist there.

6 – The corridor fight

1. The party leaves the storeroom toward the passage at the middle of the corridor. It narrows to a doorway; the chamber beyond is shadowed and silent.
2. ***[EPIC]*** Combat opens before Nuberroca clears the threshold. A cultist runs into the doorway; Nyx's first shot punches through his face and *drops him on the spot*. The body falls and the doorway is briefly clear.
3. More cultists pile in behind him. Two press up to the door at speed; a third hangs back beside two crossbow guards along the far wall. The cultists try to crowd the doorway against Amidamaru — the tortle plants himself in the gap, dodging and shouting back into the corridor for the others to stay clear and to leave one of the cultists alive for questioning.
4. Sinsong, behind Amidamaru, conjures a sword of *pale spirit-light* beside the doorway and it cuts the first cultist in a hard arc.
5. Amidamaru, seeing three cultists line up cleanly behind the second wave, lifts the alchemical mask at his throat and fans a cone of fire down the corridor. Two of the three duck in time behind their cover; the third takes the full burst and goes down moments later.
6. From a side chamber a robed woman strides out, calm. Mialee names her aloud — **Frulam Mondath**. With a small gesture she conjures a sword of pale spirit-light beside her, and sends it skimming forward toward the doorway; the blade tracks Nyx first along the corridor wall.
7. On her next beat Frulam fixes on Amidamaru in the gap and speaks a simple command: *"Tortuga, al suelo."* Amidamaru's knees fold under him before he can argue. The conjured blade pares him from above as he tries to recover, and Amidamaru cannot rise without making it worse.
8. Mialee shoots out of cover and lands a hit on Frulam, but the priestess manages to keep her concentration on the sword.
9. Nyx's second arrow finds another cultist in the chest. Eguzkilore's bow tracks the line — patient shots, mostly into the crossbow guards behind the cover at the far wall.
10. Frulam turns from Amidamaru to Nuberroca, who has just shouldered into the doorway; she lets the spirit-sword over Amidamaru dissolve and speaks a holding-word. Nuberroca freezes in place, *paralysed*, the rage still on him but his limbs locked.

11. Sinsong, seeing his opening, throws a sleep-spell at Frulam — it clips her: for a beat she stands frozen, unable to act, but does not go down. The effect is enough to break her concentration and Nuberroca can move again. Two berserkers push into the corridor behind her.
12. Amidamaru fans an acid spray down a thirty-foot lane — half the chamber catches some of it; one berserker takes the full hit, the other and Frulam herself manage to avoid the worst of it.
13. The priestess, recovered from the stupor thanks to the acid spray, drives her halberd into Nuberroca and leaves the goliath with *only a sliver of life*.
14. The combat reshapes in a single beat. Two more barbarian berserkers in cult colours push in from the back chamber — axes already swinging — and behind them comes **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** himself.
15. ***[EPIC]*** Langdedrosa pushes through into the corridor and stands between the party and Frulam, shielding her. He fixes Nuberroca across the doorway and speaks in a voice the goliath knows: *"Tú. Veo que sobreviviste a tus heridas, no seré tan generoso esta vez."*
16. Sinsong throws another sleep-spell, catching Frulam and one of the berserkers — both fold where they stand.
17. A barbarian swings on Amidamaru, but a flash of light covers the tortle and the axe slides aside, doing no damage.
18. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee breaks cover for a clean shot at one of the new arrivals. The arrow strikes home and the berserker bends his knee, visibly wounded.
19. Langdedrosa stoops over Frulam and shakes her awake; Nuberroca, with a swift cleave of his axe, finishes off the wounded berserker.
20. Another berserker badly hits Amidamaru — the axe should have killed him outright, but a wash of *pale blue light* moves across his shell where the steel bit, preventing some of the damage. The tortle drops to a sliver and stays upright, then disengages and runs back down the corridor.
21. Frulam, now awake, fires off another spirit-sword and sends it at Sinsong. The conjured blade catches him cleanly — a *critical strike to the chest*. The dwarf is hurled into the wall by the impact, his old neck tattoo flaring; he slides down the stones bleeding but standing.
22. Enraged, Frulam calls a beam of light down on the dwarf, finally dropping him. The sleeping berserker awakens.
23. Mialee shoots Frulam — the arrow barely grazes her but the hit is enough to break her concentration. The spirit-sword over Sinsong dissolves.
24. Langdedrosa, hemmed in, opens his jaws and breathes lightning down the corridor — a *clean white line* straight through the doorway. Nuberroca half-evades behind the entrance; Eguzkilore is in the open and takes the full force, gear smoking; Sinsong, lying flat, is missed by inches. The line leaves everyone in the corridor *barely standing* — Nuberroca and Eguzkilore staggered, Sinsong still out, Mialee and Nyx down to a sliver.
25. The line breaks. Nuberroca disengages and pulls back out of the doorway. Eguzkilore moves up to where Sinsong lies, hauls the dwarf over his shoulder, and starts the run back the way they came. Nyx covers their retreat from the far end of the corridor with her bow.